

COGNITIVE BEHAVIORAL THERAPY (CBT) – SESSION 6

New Case: Rohan (26 y/o) – Contamination OCD + Checking

Highly Detailed – Realistic Style

SESSION INFORMATION

Client:	Rohan (26 years, Male, Software Engineer, Bangalore)	Therapist:	Dr. A.
Session #:	6 of 18–20	Focus:	Continuing ERP + Reviewing Progress

PRE-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

Client arrived looking more confident and less ashamed than previous sessions. He practiced the first hierarchy item (touching clean tissue paper and delaying washing) at home 4 times during the week. He reported that anxiety rose initially but decreased over time in most attempts. He still washed more than desired on some days but was able to delay significantly more often. Today's plan: Review home ERP practice in detail, continue ERP with the next item on the hierarchy (touching door handle at home), reinforce coping skills, address any difficulties, and assign new homework. Maintain supportive and encouraging approach.

SESSION START – HOMEWORK REVIEW

Therapist: Good morning, Rohan. How has your week been? I'm curious to hear how the home practice with the tissue paper went.

Client: (speaking with noticeably more energy and openness) It was better than I expected. I practiced touching the tissue paper and delaying washing 4 times. The first two times, anxiety went up to about 35–40 and then slowly came down over 5–7 minutes. By the fourth time, the anxiety only went up to around 25 and came down faster. I still washed my hands afterward, but I was able to wait much longer than before. I also noticed that on days when I used labeling, it was easier to delay other compulsions too.

Therapist: That's excellent progress. You're experiencing habituation — the anxiety naturally decreasing with repeated practice. You're also generalizing the skill (using labeling to help with other compulsions). How are you feeling about these changes?

Client: I feel a bit more hopeful. I didn't think I could handle the anxiety without washing immediately. Seeing that it comes down on its own has made me feel slightly more in control. I'm still washing more than I want to, but I'm delaying more often now.

CONTINUING ERP – NEXT HIERARCHY ITEM

Therapist: Since the first item went well, I'd like to suggest we move to the next item on your hierarchy today — touching a door handle at home and then delaying washing for a longer period (aiming for 5–10 minutes). We can do a practice here first, and then you can continue at home. How does that sound?

Client: I think I can try that. The tissue paper one felt manageable after some practice, so maybe this will be okay too.

Therapist: Great. Let's do it step by step. I'll ask you to touch this door handle (inside the therapy room). Then we'll notice the thoughts and anxiety that come up. You can use labeling and breathing. We'll stay with the anxiety without washing for as long as you can tolerate, aiming for at least 5 minutes. Afterward, you can wash normally. Ready when you are.

(In-session exposure conducted: Rohan touched the door handle. Initial anxiety rose to around 45/100 with strong urge to wash. He practiced labeling ("This is an OCD thought") and diaphragmatic breathing. After 6 minutes, anxiety decreased to around 20/100. He reported feeling surprised but encouraged that the urge weakened over time. Post-exposure processing and debriefing done.)

Therapist: How was that experience for you?

Client: It was harder than the tissue paper one, but I could handle it. The anxiety went up, but then it started coming down after a few minutes. The urge to wash was strong at first but became weaker. I feel a bit proud that I was able to wait without washing immediately.

Therapist: That's a big step. You're learning through experience that you can tolerate the anxiety and that it naturally decreases. This is the core of ERP — teaching your brain that the feared outcome doesn't happen and that you can handle the discomfort. How confident are you feeling about practicing this at home?

Client: I think I can try it at home 3–4 times this week. I'm still nervous, but today's practice gave me more confidence.

HOMEWORK ASSIGNMENT

Therapist: For this week:

1. Practice touching a door handle at home and delaying washing for 5–10 minutes (3–4 times during the week)
2. Continue practicing the tissue paper exposure if it still causes some anxiety
3. Continue labeling and monitoring

Client: I'll try the door handle one at home. I feel more prepared after today's session.

Therapist: Excellent. We'll review how it went next session and decide on the next step together.

SESSION SUMMARY & FEEDBACK

Therapist: Today we reviewed your home practice, did the next hierarchy item in session (touching a door handle), and saw good habituation again. How are you feeling about today's session?

Client: I feel more confident than last week. Doing the exposure here and seeing the anxiety come down again helped a lot. I'm still scared of some of the higher items on the list, but I think I can keep going with the smaller ones for now.

Therapist: That's completely fair and realistic. Any questions before we finish?

Client: Not really.

POST-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

- Client showed clear progress in ERP practice. Successfully completed second hierarchy item in session with good habituation.
- Client reported increased confidence and willingness to continue ERP after experiencing anxiety naturally decreasing.
- Motivation and engagement remain strong. Shame appears to be decreasing as client experiences success with exposures.
- Next session: Review home ERP practice, continue ERP with next hierarchy item if ready, reinforce coping skills, address any difficulties or avoidance.

Disclaimer: This is a completely fictional but realistic simulation created solely for educational and AI training purposes. It does not represent any real person or therapy.